

House-Warming PARTY

The first full session of Parliament ran short on legislative performance with its many young and women MPs failing to live up to the expectations

| By Shafi Rahman |

The first full session of the 15th Lok Sabha had an unsolicited visitor. The wife of freshman MP E.T. Muhammed Basheer got lost in the history-choked arteries of Parliament and made her way into the Lower House instead of the visitors' gallery and sat through the proceedings for a few minutes. It took a while until the Lok Sabha watch and ward realised the folly and politely asked her to move out. The spouse's popping-up act that could fetch a fine of Rs 500 can be pardoned for her ingenuousness. But the others, elected and paid to keep democracy humming, weren't doing any better. The first full session of the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha is running short on legislative performance with its many young and women MPs failing to live up to the halo built around their entry into the House.

The UPA Government went off the block with copious comfort earned from the renewed mandate and the "obstructionist" Left stepping down from around its neck. Its ministers, heading sundry sectors, went into overdrive, announcing 100-day programmes as the Manmohan Singh-led Government stood relishing the hoopla. Human Resources Development Minister Kapil Sibal harped on bringing in private investment in the education sector and allowing foreign universities. Law Minister M. Veerappa Moily stressed on judicial reforms and Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh ensured environmental clearances will not be obstacles to growth. But nothing was said about legal framework and financial provisions to ensure any of these reforms. As BJP leader Murli Manohar Joshi put it,

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Manmohan borrowed "Trust but Verify" dictum from the book of Ronald Reagan, who had in turn picked it up from a Russian spy chief.

